The military might be brutal, venal and corrupt, but they also believe their own claims that only they really embody the spirit of the nation and only their power holds Myanmar together.

The role of the NLD

After boycotting the 2010 elections, the NLD changed tack when the ban on Aung San Suu Kyi taking part in elections was lifted.[38] As a result the NLD took part in the small number of by-elections that occurred in 2012 and won most of the seats where it stood.[39] While this provided clear evidence that, at least in Burman-dominated regions, the NLD retained massive popularity, the return to the political arena brought a further shift in tactics. After 2011 Aung San Suu Kyi started to temper her criticism of the regime in terms of both progress towards democracy and the treatment of ethnic minorities.[40] The decision of the NLD to re-enter electoral politics brought direct benefits to the regime. President Obama hailed it as evidence of what he called 'flickers of progress'.[41] Equally, for the first time it was announced that Myanmar would take its turn as chair of the ASEAN group of nations after 2014,[42] which might partly be seen as a reward for the improvements in democracy and human rights.

As we have seen in the section on the USDP, the result has been a period of relative goodwill between it and the NLD. With no elections imminent after the limited set in 2012, the two parties could afford to co-exist and both gained from the relationship. The NLD was able to exploit its legal status to build a wider party apparatus and the regime gained international approval for appearing to oversee a move towards democracy. Of course, as we will see later, this era of cosy co-existence was also marked by open violence in Rakhine and the systemic destruction of the few rights that the Rohingyas had retained during military rule.

However, the build up to the 2015 elections tested the relatively good relations between the NLD and the USDP. In the run up to the 2015 elections, there was growing evidence that while the NLD now forms a part of the Myanmar political system, it lacks the power to directly challenge the military's control over the state, retaining weaknesses that were evident in 2010.[43] Recent events connected with the August 2015 ousting of the USDP president Shwe Mann over his links with the NLD indicate a degree